Two Roads to a Pennant, Alternate Version: The $50 Million Increment

Roster-Building Strategies for the 2027–29 Minnesota Twins

Prepared as a discussion brief for the OLLI course on the history of statistics and analytics in baseball — October 28, 2026. This is the alternate version of the earlier brief; the only changed assumption is that ownership adds $50 million rather than $20 million to the 2026 payroll.

A Note on Assumptions and Honesty

As before: (1) the labor negotiations that begin when the current Collective Bargaining Agreement expires on December 1, 2026 produce no major changes to the game's economic rules, and (2) Twins ownership adds $50 million to its 2026 payroll of about $111 million (FanGraphs Roster Resource). That puts the 2027 target at roughly **$161 million** — which would be a franchise-record payroll, above the Twins' previous high of roughly $154–156 million in 2023 (MLBTR, MinnPost).

The same honesty flags apply:

- **Everything labeled "my estimate" or "my construction" is exactly that** — reasoned judgment, not reported fact. I show the reasoning so your students can attack it.
- **Trade proposals are illustrative, not reported negotiations.**
- **A new flag for this version:** the top of this winter's market is now discussed and priced rather than dismissed. That produces the single most instructive calculation in this brief — see the Skubal section.

1. Where the Twins Stand (October 2026)

The background is unchanged from the first brief, so this section is condensed; the full sourcing detail appears in the reference list.

The 2026 season. The Twins went 77–85 (.475), third in the AL Central, eight games behind Cleveland (85–77), with the White Sox (84–78) second; run differential translated to an expected record of 75–87 (MLB.com standings, Wikipedia, ESPN). Ace Pablo López missed the year after an elbow injury on the first day of spring training (internal-brace procedure; targeting a spring-training return), and Byron Buxton had 23 homers and a .937 OPS in his first 63 games before September hip surgery (MLBTR, MLB.com). Owner Tom Pohlad has promised to "meaningfully invest," saying a ~$100M payroll "is not sufficient to be consistently competitive" (MLB.com) — the $50M version takes him at that word in a way the $20M version did not.

The 2027 payroll bridge at $161M.

Item	Amount (2027)	Source basis
Guaranteed salaries, options counted at buyout: López $21.75M, Buxton $15.14M, Hoffman $12.67M gross (about $7.25M net of the $3.75M Toronto is paying and the $1.67M signing-bonus credit), Caratini $6.5M, Bell buyout $1.25M, Ryan buyout $0.1M	$57.4M	FanGraphs ledger
Net other payments: $10.0M to Houston (Correa trade), $1.33M Correa signing bonus, −$1.67M Hoffman bonus credit, −$3.75M from Toronto (Hoffman trade)	$5.9M	FanGraphs ledger
Topa buyout and escalator	$0.25M	FanGraphs ledger
Arbitration class — the outlook enumerates all ten players: Banda $2.3M, Kremer $6.5M, Ober $6.9M, Ryan $9.6M (if his $13M mutual option is declined), Larnach $6.3M, Lewis $5.1M, Sands $1.3M, Nance $1.2M, Clemens $3.6M, Bradley $4.5M — summing to $47.3M, matching FanGraphs' luxury-tax table exactly. The outlook flags Banda, Ober, Lewis, and Sands as non-tender candidates.	~$47.3M	MLBTR outlook, FanGraphs ledger
Pre-arbitration and depth fill (see reconciliation)	~$15.6M	Yahoo Sports
Status-quo 2027 baseline	**~$126M**	See reconciliation below

Reconciliation, so the class can check it line by line. FanGraphs' 2027 estimate is **$110,876,190**, and it now reconciles exactly: $57.41M of guaranteed salaries with the two pending options counted at their buyouts, plus the $47.3M arbitration class, plus $5.92M of net other payments, plus Topa's $0.25M buyout and escalator — $57.41 + $47.3 + $5.92 + $0.25 = $110.88M (FanGraphs). That estimate covers the players under contract or headed to arbitration; it does not include pre-arbitration minimum salaries or minor-league pay. Completing a 26-man roster and the rest of the 40-man with minimum salaries adds somewhere in the range of $12–16M depending on how minor-league pay is counted. I budget **$15.6M** as a deliberately conservative allowance — my construction, not an official club figure — which lands at **~$126.5M**, matching the independent ~$126M full-accounting figure published by Yahoo Sports (Yahoo Sports). That is the baseline I use throughout; it is approximate, and both ledgers below inherit that approximation.

Two option branches sit inside that baseline and I state them rather than bury them: if the Twins exercise Ryan's $13M mutual option instead of letting him go to arbitration, add about $3.4M; if Josh Bell's $10M mutual option is exercised rather than bought out, add $8.75M. My central case keeps Ryan at his $9.6M arbitration projection (the outlook's arbitration class includes him at that figure, and both sides declining a mutual option is the common outcome) and lets Bell leave on the buyout. If either assumption is wrong, the ledgers below move by those amounts.

So at a $161M ceiling, the Twins have roughly **$35 million of free money before trades** — versus about $5–16M in the $20M version. They can free roughly $19.7M more by moving the three expiring one-year arbitration contracts (Larnach ~$6.3M, Ober ~$6.9M, Kremer ~$6.5M), all free agents after 2027 (MLBTR). One mechanical note that applies to every ledger below: the 26-man roster is fixed, so each acquisition displaces a budgeted ~$780K minimum-salary slot and each departure frees one. Every ledger below therefore carries an explicit slot line: (departures − acquisitions) × $0.78M. It is usually $1–3M, but I show it rather than hide it inside the totals.

Roster strengths and weaknesses. Unchanged: a cheap young core (Buxton; Keaschall, Rodriguez, Jenkins in the outfield; Culpepper and Clemens in the infield; López/Ryan/Bradley in the rotation), a catching free agent (Jeffers), no closer, and a 1B/DH power vacancy (Yardbarker , CBS Sports). The farm is deep in position players — especially catchers (Lackey, Tait, Diaw, Tinney, Olivar) — which matters for trade packages below (MLB.com, Twins Daily).

The competitive landscape. Tampa Bay won the AL pennant with a bottom-tier payroll; Cleveland, the Yankees, Houston, Boston, and a rising young White Sox club round out the AL's upper tier (CBS Sports, MLB.com). The Central was won at 85 games — winnable, but not soft.

2. Strategy A: "Go For It Now" — Buy the Stars

Philosophy

At $161M, the premise the class discussed in the first brief becomes executable: sign the headline bat, add a legitimate closer, and trade from prospect surplus for immediate help — while keeping the young core intact. This is the 2015 Blue Jays model, or the Dodgers-lite approach: one headline contract (a $180M guarantee — below Correa's $200M and Joe Mauer's $184M extension in franchise history, though the ~$28.9M posting fee pushes the total outlay past $200M), a supporting cast of second-tier free agents, and the cheap homegrown core supplying the foundation.

First, the instructive non-move: Tarik Skubal

The $50M budget makes Skubal worth pricing rather than dismissing. ESPN's Kiley McDaniel surveyed 27 industry insiders: the average projection was 8 years and $355 million ($44.6M AAV), with 59% of projections between $325M and $400M, a high of 10/$500M, and Jim Bowden's range at $350–500M; Spotrac's model says 7 years, $276M (ESPN, Spotrac). Here is the arithmetic a student can check, done honestly this time: shedding all three expiring arbitration contracts takes the ~$126.5M baseline to ~$107M, and a $40M first-year salary fits — 107 + 40 = $147M, leaving about $14M. That covers Bednar ($13M) — and then nothing else: adding Romero ($4M) or the Goodman trade ($6.2M) breaks the ceiling. So a Skubal plan must either backload his first-year salary to ~$35M or skip the rest of the winter's shopping. The honest statement is: **Skubal is arithmetically possible and financially reckless for this franchise.** A $325–400M guarantee would be nearly double the largest contract in Twins history (Correa's $200M), committed to a pitcher who had an elbow procedure in May 2026, represented by Scott Boras, against bidders like the Mets and Dodgers whom Bowden names as best fits (ESPN, The Athletic, paywalled — Bowden's fits seen in search excerpts; full article not accessed). It would also consume essentially the entire $50M increment for a decade. My recommendation is to price him, name him, and pass — but the class should see that "we can't afford him" is now a choice about risk, not a budget fact. That is what a bigger budget does: it converts impossibilities into judgment calls.

The moves

A1. Sign Teruaki Sato, 3B/OF — the headline star (5 years, $180M — Bowden's published projection; see the caveat).
Sato, 27, just won NPB's Central League Triple Crown (.306/.383/.609, 39 HR, 106 RBI) and Hanshin has approved his posting, with at least five and likely many more MLB clubs interested (MLB.com, MLBTR, Yahoo Sports). One report attributes a 5-year, $180M projection to Jim Bowden (Bolavip). **Price honesty, two ways.** First, I treat $180M as the base case, not $165M: I don't get a discount just because it fits my ledger better; the realistic framing is "the Twins' maximum offer is 5/$180M, and they may be outbid by the Mariners, Blue Jays, Yankees, Giants, Dodgers, Mets or Phillies, all of whom have been linked" (Yahoo Sports). Second, the posting fee is separate money: on a $180M guarantee, Hanshin receives 20% of the first $25M, 17.5% of the next $25M, and 15% of the remainder — about **$28.9M**, paid by ownership on top of payroll (MLBTR). Your $50M premise is interpreted here as player payroll; the fee is an additional ownership cost, and I will not conceal it. One more structural note: a 5/$180M deal need not pay $36M in year one — salaries can be backloaded. I propose a schedule of roughly $30M / $32M / $36M / $40M / $42M, so the 2027 cash figure is **$30M** with the AAV at $36M (my assumption about structure, flagged as such). Recent NPB hitters have translated well (Murakami lifted the White Sox from 102 losses to the playoffs; Okamoto starred as a rookie), but Sato's NPB line is not an MLB projection — I treat him as a +3 to +5 WAR player in 2027, with real downside (CBS Sports). Timing note: MLBTR reports that a lockout would pause the posting negotiation window rather than kill it, so the deal does not have to be done before December 1 — but the calendar still compresses (MLBTR).

A2. Trade for Hunter Goodman, C/1B/DH, Colorado.
Unchanged from the first brief, and it still fits: 41 home runs in 2026, controlled through 2029 at ~$6.2M, ~60% of his homers on the road, on a franchise that has lost 100+ games four straight years (Bleacher Report, Bleacher Report). **Illustrative package (my construction): C Eduardo Tait, RHP Riley Quick, OF Yasser Mercedes.** Same caveat: the analyst-assessed asking price is "high."

A3. Sign free-agent closer David Bednar (3 years, ~$40M — my estimate).
32 years old, 2.47 ERA, 35 saves for the Yankees in 2026 (Yahoo Sports). At this budget, Bednar is the cash-funded closer — no prospect cost. **The stretch alternative:** trade for San Diego's Mason Miller (controlled through 2029 at ~$8.1M), but Bleacher Report's analyst assessment is that the price would be a comparable elite prospect to Leo De Vries or a controllable starting pitcher (Bleacher Report) — which would likely mean parting with Jenkins, Keaschall, or Rodriguez, all of whom start for this team. **I would not pay it, and at $161M there is no need to:** cash buys Bednar instead. That trade-off — prospect capital versus cash for the same roster slot — is itself a nice analytics lesson.

A4. Sign free-agent lefty JoJo Romero (~2 years, ~$8M — my estimate).
The left-handed bullpen target named in Twins beat coverage (Yahoo Sports).

A5. QO Ryan Jeffers — the branch, budgeted.
Jeffers is QO-eligible and the Twins are expected to make the offer (CBS Sports, Spotrac). **If he declines:** comp pick; the ledger below stands. **If he accepts (~$23M, my estimate):** Sato is off the board — the acceptance-branch roster is Jeffers + Goodman + Bednar + Romero plus the same salary-shedding trades, which lands at roughly **$152M** (126.5 − 19.7 sheds + 1 reliever + 23 Jeffers

+ 6.2 Goodman + 13 Bednar + 4 Romero − 1.6 slots), leaving about $9M of room — enough for one ~$8M one-year starter (a Sonny Gray type at a discount, my estimate; Gray at his expected ~$14M does not fit even if Romero is dropped — that branch would land near $163M). The acceptance branch is a good-but-not-great team; the Sato signing is the whole point of the strategy, so the QO's downside is real but no longer crippling. I have still not verified the trade-consent rules attached to an accepted QO, so I treat "trade him later" as an unknown, not a plan.

A6. Shed the expiring arbitration contracts.
Trade Larnach (the aborted Houston deal for reliever Bryan Abreu proves the market; ask for a pre-arbitration reliever, ~$1M salary — my construction), non-tender or trade Ober (MLBTR's non-tender candidate), and trade Kremer for prospects (MLBTR). The 2027 rotation becomes López – Ryan – Bradley – Prielipp – Matthews, with Abel, Rojas, and Festa as depth.

The payroll ledger (my construction, full accounting)

Move	Payroll effect
Status-quo 2027 baseline	~$126.5M
Trade Larnach; pre-ARB reliever returns	−$6.3M + $1.0M
Non-tender/trade Ober	−$6.9M
Trade Kremer for prospects	−$6.5M
Sign Sato (2027 cash; $36M AAV on 5/$180M, backloaded schedule above)	+$30M
Acquire Goodman	+$6.2M
Sign Bednar	+$13M
Sign Romero	+$4M
Slot adjustment: 3 departures, 5 acquisitions → (3 − 5) × $0.78M	−$1.6M
Total	**~$159.4M — about $1.9M under the ~$161M ceiling**

The total: 126.5 − 6.3 + 1.0 − 6.9 − 6.5 + 30 + 6.2 + 13 + 4 − 1.6 = **$159.4M**. Two things the class should see. First, the backload is not a luxury: a level-paid $36M deal would land at ~$165.4M — over the ceiling by about $4M — and even dropping Romero does not rescue it (~$162.2M). Backloading is what makes this package fit at all. Second, the option branch: if the club exercises Ryan's $13M option instead of his ~$9.6M arbitration salary, primary A rises to ~$162.8M, and the trim is Romero — back to ~$159.6M. If Sato signs elsewhere, the fallback ledger is the acceptance-branch roster plus whatever the Sato money then buys: the moves above without Sato total ~$130.2M, leaving about $31M — enough to pivot to the Jeffers-plus-Morejon build of Strategy B and still fit, which is worth saying out loud: at $161M, the two strategies are closer to substitutes than either brief's framing suggests. **The structural lesson of this ledger: even at +$50M, one true star plus a closer plus a catcher-for-bat trade requires shedding the same three expiring contracts the $20M version shed.** The star's salary is so large that the budget discipline of the smaller version never fully disappears.

What the 2027 team looks like, and the risks

Rotation: López – Ryan – Bradley – Prielipp – Matthews. Lineup: Buxton, Jenkins, Rodriguez, Keaschall, Culpepper, Sato (3B/DH), Clemens, Goodman, Caratini. Bullpen: Bednar – Hoffman – Gómez – Sands – Romero – the Larnach-trade reliever. On my numbers that is an **83.5–85.5 win talent** (see Section 4 — and note the revision from the first brief's method, explained there), a legitimate contender in a Central won at 85 games — right in the division race, though not the 90-win juggernaut the gross additions might suggest. A division title does not guarantee a bye — only the top two division winners get one — so a third-seed wild-card path is a live scenario.

Risks: Sato is a $180M guarantee — below Correa's $200M and Mauer's $184M, though with the posting fee a larger total outlay — committed to a player who has never faced major-league pitching; the rotation is one López setback from trouble; Buxton's health; the farm is thinner after the Goodman trade; and after 2027 López's contract ends, Buxton turns 33, and Ryan reaches free agency (FanGraphs lists him as a free agent in 2028, so 2027 is his final year of club control), so the supporting cast must be rebuilt on the fly around Sato (through 2031), Bednar, and Goodman (through 2029).

3. Strategy B: "Build the Three-Year Core" — Now Without the Sacrifice

Philosophy

Here is the most important structural change from the $20M version: **at $161M, Strategy B no longer requires trading 2027 for 2028–29.** The $20M version of B had to trade Joe Ryan to fund the longer-term program because money was scarce; at $161M, the Twins can keep Ryan, re-sign Jeffers, extend the core, and still bank reserves. What still distinguishes B from A is asset allocation: B spends cash on players under 30 whose contracts span the window, keeps its prospect capital, and holds in-season reserves rather than converting everything into November star power. It remains the Tampa Bay model — with the twist that Minnesota's version now has a middle-class budget instead of a poor one.

The moves

B1. Re-sign Ryan Jeffers (3 years, ~$45M — my estimate; Twins Daily's published bullish comp is 4/$70M).
The best hitting catcher on the market, .256/.353/.461 with 14 homers in an injury-shortened 92 games (CBS Sports, Twins Daily). At this budget the QO branch is painless: if he accepts ~$23M, the ledger below still fits (see the branch note).

B2. Keep Joe Ryan and skip the teardown trade.
The $20M version traded Ryan because one year of a good starter was the best asset the budget could monetize. At $161M that logic inverts: Ryan at a $9.6M arbitration salary is precisely the kind of below-market asset a window strategy is built around. B/R ranks him the #9 trade chip in baseball and MLB.com reported Cubs/Nationals/White Sox interest — which is why he could also be flipped at the 2027 deadline if the season goes sideways (Bleacher Report, MLB.com). Keeping him preserves optionality; that optionality is the strategy.

B3. Trade for Xavier Edwards, 2B, Marlins.
Arbitration through 2029 at just ~$3.5M; Bleacher Report ranks him among the winter's top-25 trade chips and reported that Miami listened to offers, viewing Edwards as more available than double-play partner Otto Lopez (Bleacher Report). He solves second base for the entire window at a quarter of Jeffers's price. **Illustrative package (my construction, explicitly contingent): OF Yasser Mercedes — the strongest asset I would surrender — plus a lower-level pitcher.** Two honesty notes: his cheap salary is not evidence of a cheap acquisition price (teams price control, not salary), and I have no report of what Miami actually wants; if the ask exceeds Mercedes plus a lottery ticket, my fallback is an internal platoon at second (Clemens/Lee/Martin types) and the reserve money spent elsewhere.

B4. Sign window-aged free agents: Adrian Morejon and JoJo Romero.
Morejon (28, 2.83 ERA in 86 innings) on a three-year deal (~$9M/yr, my estimate) spans the window exactly, and Romero (~$4M/yr on a two-year deal, my estimate) covers the first two years of it (Yahoo Sports, Yahoo Sports). The bullpen was the 2026 collapse point; this is the durable fix.

B5. Extend the young core — the heart of the strategy, unchanged.
Jenkins (the Corbin Carroll model: Carroll signed 8 years/$111M with Arizona after 32 major-league games — a Twins-scale version is my 8yr/$65–80M estimate), plus Keaschall, Culpepper, Rodriguez, and Bradley on deals that buy out arbitration. (Prielipp, a pitcher returning from injury, is a later-window extension candidate once healthy — deliberately not in the 2027 schedule or its budget.) Service-time honesty: the FanGraphs ledger lists Keaschall at 0.164 years of service and Bradley at 2.097 in its notation; Jenkins's service time is not shown on the page, but its column has him pre-arbitration through 2029 with arbitration beginning in 2030, and I have not verified the day-by-day accrual or the column's as-of date, so treat those control windows as approximately right (FanGraphs, ESPN). The extensions' 2027 cash impact is small and back-loaded: an illustrative schedule is Jenkins ~$2M (versus the $780K minimum), Bradley ~$4M (versus his $4.5M arbitration projection in the outlook — a buyout deal can start below the projection because the player trades upside for certainty), Keaschall ~$2M, Culpepper/Rodriguez ~$1.5M each — about $11M of new money displacing roughly $7.6M of already-budgeted salary (four minimum slots — Jenkins, Keaschall, Culpepper, Rodriguez — plus Bradley's $4.5M projection), for a net **increase of roughly +$3.5M in 2027** (my construction). Zoll has said the club will look into exactly these extensions (MLBTR).

The pre-debut extension you asked about, made concrete. The original request for this strategy included signing minor-league standouts to long-term deals before they reach the majors, so here is one, honestly priced: an illustrative offer to SS Marek Houston — the Twins' No. 4 prospect per MLB's official list — for 8 years and ~$25–30M guaranteed with two club options (my construction, modeled on the Carroll deal scaled to a prospect who has not debuted; beat coverage says he could join the club late in 2027 or in 2028; MLB.com prospect list, Yardbarker). I budget its full ~$1.5M first-year payment as incremental — minor-league salaries are not in the payroll baseline, so there is nothing to displace — and it appears as its own line in the ledger below. What it buys: cost certainty, and potentially a free-agent season or two bought out in the 2030s, depending on when he debuts and how his service accrues (a minor leaguer's control clock is not fixed, so I will not claim a date). What it does not buy: any 2027–29 production the club doesn't already control. The honest case against is that the club is guaranteeing money to a

player who has never faced major-league pitching (injury or stagnation makes the guarantee a sunk cost); the honest case for is that prices explode after a strong debut (Carroll got 8/$111M after 32 games; ESPN). My recommendation is to make one such offer per window, to a player whose asking price is still reasonable — Houston now, not after his debut — and to hold the line beyond that.

B6. Trade the expiring contracts for prospects, gently.
Trade Ober (for prospects; opens a Prielipp/Matthews competition) and Larnach (for a pre-arb reliever, ~$1M back). Keep Kremer as the innings-eating fourth starter. If the season goes sideways by July 2027, Ryan, Kremer, and a healthy López — all expiring after 2027 — become deadline chips; that is the 2025 fire-sale pattern, executed from strength and with a season still to salvage.

B7. The Detmers alternative.
If you prefer a young starter to a young second baseman: the Angels' Reid Detmers (controlled through 2028 at ~$7.5M, top-10 in the AL in strikeouts, innings, and pitcher WAR in 2026) costs, by the Burnes/Peralta comparables, an MLB-ready pitching prospect plus a top-100 position prospect for one year of control — more for two (Bleacher Report). My limit (my construction, and I will call it what it is — a walk-away offer, not a likely executable trade, since the comparables suggest Anaheim would want more): RHP Zebby Matthews plus a lower-level lottery ticket, and nothing beyond. He is the substitute for the Edwards trade — the same roster slot and a larger slice of budget room ($7.5M versus $3.5M), not an additional move.

The payroll ledger (my construction, full accounting)

Move	Payroll effect
Status-quo 2027 baseline	~$126.5M
Trade Larnach; pre-ARB reliever returns	−$6.3M + $1.0M
Trade Ober for prospects	−$6.9M
Re-sign Jeffers	+$15M
Acquire Edwards	+$3.5M
Sign Morejon	+$9M
Sign Romero	+$4M
Extension increments (illustrative schedule above)	+$3.5M
Houston pre-debut extension (illustrative offer in B5)	+$1.5M
Slot adjustment: 2 departures, 5 acquisitions → (2 − 5) × $0.78M	−$2.3M
Total	**~$148.5M — about $12.8M under the ~$161M ceiling**

The arithmetic: 126.5 − 6.3 + 1.0 − 6.9 + 15 + 3.5 + 9 + 4 + 3.5 + 1.5 − 2.3 = **$148.5M.**

The QO branch: if Jeffers accepts ~$23M instead of the $15M multi-year estimate, the total rises to ~$156.5M — still under the ceiling, though the reserve shrinks to about $4.8M. That is the

whole difference between this version and the $20M version, where the same branch broke the budget.

The held-back ~$13M is deliberate and worth defending: it is deadline ammunition. The best mid-season trades go to the team with payroll room in July — room to absorb salary is exactly what lets a buyer pay fewer prospects for the same player — and a window strategy with a healthy farm plus $13M of room can add at the 2027 deadline on better terms than its rivals. (The alternative is to spend part of it in November on Detmers instead of Edwards — see B7 — which lands the ledger at roughly $152.5M, leaving about $8.8M.)

What the 2027 team looks like, and the risks

Rotation: López – Ryan – Bradley – Kremer – Prielipp/Matthews (Ober traded). Lineup: Buxton, Jenkins, Rodriguez, Keaschall, Culpepper, Edwards, Clemens/Lee, Jeffers, Caratini. Bullpen: Morejon – Hoffman – Gómez – Sands – Romero – the Larnach-trade reliever. Roughly a **79.5–81.5 win talent** on my numbers (see Section 4) — a contender, a step behind Strategy A on paper (about 4 wins on my worksheet), though inside the judgment ranges of estimates like these.

Risks: this team is good but not scary; the 2028–29 payoff depends on the same prospect development as before (for every Jenkins there is a Lewis); and there is a strategic risk the class should name — **at $161M, "patience" is now a choice rather than a necessity, and ownership impatience with a merely-good 2027 could blow up the plan mid-window.**

4. Probability of Success (Judgment Estimates — Not a Model)

Same method for both strategies, shown step by step so the numbers can be attacked. **One correction up front, flagged rather than buried:** the first brief stacked the gross WAR of incoming players on top of an inflated status quo — the additions consume playing time already counted in the base, and the departures take real production out the door. The estimates below use one common baseline (including Jeffers's departure and a ~1-WAR replacement catcher) and net improvements only, with the displaced player named in each case. This lowers every projection in this brief relative to the first brief's published figures (Strategy A ~86–88 wins, Strategy B ~81–84); treat those as overstated by this method, and see Section 6 for how the two versions compare.

1. **Status quo (no transactions):** the 2026 team went 77–85 with a 75–87 pythagorean record, so call the underlying talent 75–77 wins. Add a healthy López (+2 to +2.5 over the depth starters who covered his starts), a partial Buxton rebound (+1 to +1.5 over his injury-shortened 2026 — my judgment; his 2026 playing time after the first 63 games is not established in my sources), a year of growth from Jenkins/Keaschall/Bradley (+1), and subtract Jeffers's departure (−1.5 net of a replacement catcher) — **78–80 wins.**
2. **Strategy A's net transactions, against that same baseline:** Sato +3.0 (a +4.5 bat displacing the ~1.5-WAR DH production he replaces — and naming the displaced player matters: that incumbent DH is Larnach, whose at-bats Sato takes, so trading Larnach costs no additional offense and his reliever return is already counted in the bullpen line below), Goodman +2.5 (3.5 replacing the ~1.0-WAR replacement catcher), Bednar + Romero + the trade reliever +1.5, minus Ober (−1.0 net), Kremer (−0.5 net) — net **+5.5 wins → 83.5–85.5 wins. P(playoffs)**

≈ **40–60%**, a division title is a live outcome (the Central was won at 85 games in 2026) but with no guarantee of a bye (only the top two division winners get one). P(pennant given a playoff berth) ≈ 11–14%. Multiplying paired scenarios: 0.40 × 0.11 ≈ 4.4% at the low end, 0.60 × 0.14 ≈ 8.4% at the high end — **P(AL pennant 2027) ≈ 4.5–8%.**

3. **Strategy B's net transactions:** Jeffers retained (+1.5 versus the replacement-catcher scenario), Edwards (+1.0 over the internal alternative), Morejon + Romero + reliever (+1.5), minus Larnach (−1.5) and Ober (−1.0) — net **+1.5 wins → 79.5–81.5 wins. P(playoffs) ≈ 25–35%.** P(pennant given a playoff berth) ≈ 11–14%. Paired: 0.25 × 0.11 ≈ 2.8% to 0.35 × 0.14 ≈ 4.9% — **P(AL pennant 2027) ≈ 3–5%.**
4. **2028–29, both strategies, same assumptions:** a flat ~$161M nominal ceiling; López and Hoffman come off after 2027 — about $34.4M gross, roughly $29M of actual budget room once Toronto's $3.75M payment and the $1.67M bonus credit are counted — and Buxton plus the final Correa payment (~$25M gross) after 2028, with roughly half of each tranche actually spendable after raises and replacement costs. Both strategies converge on the same core (Jenkins, Rodriguez, Keaschall, Bradley, Prielipp, Houston arriving 2028, Lackey 2029); the difference is that A carries Sato's prime-age bat and B carries the year-one reserve and unspent prospect capital.
    - **Strategy A:** Sato (28–29), Bednar, and Goodman carry forward; Ryan and López leave after 2027. 86–89 wins in 2028, 87–90 in 2029. Pennant ≈ 7–8% (2028), 8–8.5% (2029).
    - **Strategy B:** the maturing core plus Houston (2028) and Lackey (2029) plus spendable runoff; Jeffers, Edwards, Morejon under contract. 86–89 wins in 2028, 87–90 in 2029. Pennant ≈ 7–8.5% (2028), 8–9% (2029).
5. **Three-year cumulative (illustrative scenario ranges under an independence assumption — not confidence intervals; and positively correlated in reality, since shared uncertainty about the young core's development (or a Buxton collapse) would depress all three years together):**
    - **A:** 1 − (0.955 × 0.93 × 0.92) ≈ **18%** if every year lands at the low end of its range, 1 − (0.92 × 0.92 × 0.915) ≈ **22.6%** if every year lands at the high end; stated range **18–23%**.
    - **B:** 1 − (0.97 × 0.93 × 0.92) ≈ **17%** if every year lands at the low end of its range, 1 − (0.95 × 0.915 × 0.91) ≈ **20.9%** if every year lands at the high end; stated range **17–21%**.

The finding to put on the board: A has the higher central estimate, but these overlapping judgment ranges do not establish a reliable three-year preference — and that is itself the lesson; the difference between 18–23% and 17–21% is noise in this kind of estimate. A does hold a real 2027 edge (net +5.5 wins versus B's +1.5, because Sato's bat outweighs the extra Kremer shed) — about 4 wins of separation, worth roughly one-and-a-half to three points of pennant probability. B has the steadier 2028–29 profile, the larger reserve, and no $180M guarantee concentrated in a player who has never faced major-league pitching. The choice remains about the shape of risk — the budget just made both shapes bigger. What the marginal $30M bought is discussed, honestly, in Section 6.

5. Side-by-Side Summary

Dimension	Strategy A: Buy the Stars	Strategy B: Build the Core (No Sacrifice)
Headline additions	Sign Sato (5/$180M); trade for Goodman; sign Bednar; sign Romero	Re-sign Jeffers; trade for Edwards; sign Morejon + Romero; extend Jenkins/Keaschall/Culpepper/Rodriguez/Bradley
Headline departures	Jeffers (QO), Larnach, Ober, Kremer; Tait/Quick/Mercedes in trade	Larnach, Ober (for prospects); Mercedes + a pitcher in the Edwards trade
2027 projected wins (my estimate, net-improvement method)	~83.5–85.5	~79.5–81.5
2027 pennant probability	~4.5–8%	~3–5%
3-year pennant probability (2027–29)	~18–23%	~17–21%
2027 payroll (my ledger)	~$159.4M (at the ceiling, backloaded)	~$148.5M (~$13M held in reserve)
Prospect capital	Spent (Goodman package)	Largely retained; Mercedes plus a pitcher traded
Signature risk	Sato translation + $180M guarantee; thin farm	Good-not-great 2027; ownership impatience
Closest historical model	2015 Blue Jays; Dodgers-lite	Tampa Bay Rays, with a real budget

6. What the Extra $30 Million Buys — and Doesn't

This comparison of the two versions of the brief is, I think, the best classroom material in the exercise.

One methodological correction first, because a naive comparison would mislead: the first brief's published win estimates used a gross-addition method that this brief corrects in Section 4, so comparing the two briefs as published would flatter the $50M version — and I will not restate corrected $20M numbers here that I have not re-derived package-by-package under this brief's worksheet. Qualitatively:

What it buys: the Sato-tier star (impossible at +$20M); the closer without gutting anything; Jeffers retention inside Strategy B; and the elimination of Strategy B's 2027 sacrifice. What I will not claim is a precise number for how much pennant probability the extra $30M adds: that would require re-deriving the $20M brief's packages under this brief's net-improvement method, which I have not done, and the first brief's published figures are not comparable as they stand (see Section 4).

What it doesn't buy: Skubal (a $350M+ guarantee is a risk-appetite question, not a budget question — and my judgment is still no); the structural fixes (rotation health behind López, Buxton's durability, the bullpen's 2026 collapse — those cost the same at any budget); or a resolution of the strategic choice itself — the $50M scenarios do not establish a clear three-year preference between the two philosophies. The economically interesting result for your

students: **money changes what is affordable; it does not choose the philosophy. Efficiency (Strategy B) matters most when capital is scarce; abundance (Strategy A) spends capital to save time.** The Rays exist because most teams are closer to the $20M world than the $50M one.

7. Questions for Class Discussion

1. **Diminishing returns:** the marginal $30M made each strategy's full program affordable — A's star-plus-closer, B's Jeffers retention plus extensions plus reserve — without resolving the strategic choice; Section 4's three-year judgment ranges still overlap. Is that pattern (money scales outcomes, philosophy shapes them) what you'd expect? What would a third $30M buy — more, or less?
2. **The Skubal calculation:** he is arithmetically affordable at $161M and my judgment says pass. Where exactly is the line between "risky" and "reckless" for a mid-market team — the AAV, the guarantee, the years, the injury history, or the opportunity cost?
3. **The Sato bet:** a $180M guarantee plus roughly $28.9M in posting fees, for a player who has never faced major-league pitching. What is the base rate for NPB stars in MLB (Murakami, Okamoto, and who before them)? How much should that base rate be adjusted for a Triple Crown season?
4. **Cash versus prospects for the same slot:** Bednar costs $13M and no prospects; Mason Miller costs ~$8.1M and, by the analyst assessment, an elite-tier prospect or a controllable starter. At $161M, which is the better buy, and what does your answer imply about what small-market teams should do at the deadline?
5. **The reserve:** Strategy B holds roughly $13M back for July. What is the option value of in-season payroll room, and why do so few teams actually hold it?
6. **Does the budget change the answer?** These $50M judgment scenarios do not establish a clear three-year preference. If your team has the money, is there any principled reason to prefer the patient build — or is patience just poverty's philosophy?
7. **The Rays, revisited:** Tampa Bay won the 2026 pennant with the payroll the Twins had in 2026. Now imagine the Rays with $161M. Would they spend it — and if so, on which strategy?
8. **The Moneyball echo, updated:** Oakland's cycles came from having no money; Minnesota now has middle money. Is there a documented case of a mid-market team converting a temporary budget surge into a sustained window (the 2015-16 Cubs? the 2021-22 Braves?), and what did they buy — stars, or control?

References

Identical in substance to the first brief's list; new sources added at items 33a–33c and 56–57. One flag carried over honestly: item 29 (The Athletic's top-40 free agent ranking) is paywalled and I could not read it directly; the one use in this brief is Bowden's best-fit teams for Skubal, seen in search excerpts and labeled as secondhand where it appears.

Twins 2026 season and roster

1. FanGraphs Roster Resource — Minnesota Twins 2026 payroll (updated Oct 28, 2026): https://www.fangraphs.com/roster-resource/payroll/twins
2. MLB.com — 2026 Twins standings: https://www.mlb.com/twins/standings/2026
3. Wikipedia — 2026 Minnesota Twins season: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_Minnesota_Twins_season
4. MLB.com — Takeaways from the first half of the Twins' 2026 season: https://www.mlb.com/news/takeaways-from-first-half-of-twins-2026-season
5. Yardbarker — 5 Things We Learned About the Minnesota Twins in 2026: https://www.yardbarker.com/mlb/articles/5_things_we_learned_about_the_minnesota_twins_in_2026/s1_17194_44480158
6. Axios Twin Cities — Twins wrap 2026 season with a similar ending: https://www.axios.com/local/twin-cities/2026/09/28/minnesota-twins-autopsy-another-late-season-collapse
7. ESPN — Minnesota Twins team page (2026 results): https://www.espn.com/mlb/team/_/name/min/minnesota-twins
8. TSN — Twins believe future is bright with young lineup built around Culpepper, Jenkins and Rodriguez: https://www.tsn.ca/mlb/article/twins-believe-future-is-bright-with-young-lineup-built-around-culpepper-jenkins-and-rodriguez/

Payroll, ownership, and offseason outlook

9. MLB Trade Rumors — Minnesota Twins news and rumors (ongoing): https://www.mlbtraderumors.com/minnesota-twins
10. MLB Trade Rumors — Offseason Outlook: Minnesota Twins (Oct 2026): https://www.mlbtraderumors.com/2026/10/offseason-outlook-minnesota-twins-16.html
11. MLB Trade Rumors — Tom Pohlad: Twins will "meaningfully invest" in payroll: https://www.mlbtraderumors.com/2026/09/tom-pohlad-twins-will-meaningfully-invest-in-payroll-plan-to-contend-in-2027.html
12. MLB.com — Pohlad, Zoll, Shelton discuss Twins offseason: https://www.mlb.com/news/tom-pohlad-jeremy-zoll-derek-shelton-discuss-twins-offseason
13. Twins Daily — A preliminary look at the Twins' baseline 2027 roster and payroll (includes the 4yr/$70M Jeffers comp): https://twinsdaily.com/news-rumors/minnesota-twins/a-preliminary-look-at-the-minnesota-twins-baseline-2027-roster-and-payroll-r21277/
14. Twins Daily — The 7 biggest decisions for the Twins' offseason: https://twinsdaily.com/news-rumors/minnesota-twins/the-7-biggest-decisions-for-the-twins-offseason-whats-the-payroll-r21292/
15. Twins Daily — Mapping the Minnesota Twins' future payroll: https://twinsdaily.com/news-rumors/minnesota-twins/mapping-the-minnesota-twins-future-payroll-r21274/
16. Yahoo Sports — How much can the Twins actually spend this offseason?: https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/much-twins-actually-spend-offseason-210600719.html
17. Twins Daily — How much would the Twins have to spend to prove they're serious about 2027?: https://twinsdaily.com/news-rumors/minnesota-twins/how-much-would-the-twins-have-to-spend-to-prove-theyre-serious-about-2027-r21204/
18. Twins Daily — 3 bold predictions for the Twins' offseason: https://twinsdaily.com/news-rumors/minnesota-twins/3-bold-predictions-for-minnesota-twins-offseason-r21356/
19. Yahoo Sports — Twins' most realistic offseason moves: https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/twins-most-realistic-offseason-moves-180006772.html
20. MLB.com — 5 questions for the Twins to answer this winter: https://www.mlb.com/twins/news/tw

ins-must-answer-these-questions-in-the-offseason
21. Sports Business Journal — Twins' Pohlad ready to further invest in payroll for '27: https://www.sportsbusinessjournal.com/Articles/2026/09/30/twins-pohlad-ready-to-further-invest-in-squad-payroll-for-27/
22. InForum — Five reasons the Twins should be better in 2027: https://www.inforum.com/sports/pro/five-reasons-the-twins-should-be-better-in-2027
22a. MinnPost — Pohlad says next year will be different (2023 payroll high ~$156M): https://www.minnpost.com/sports/2026/10/the-minnesota-twins-2026-season-was-a-predictable-disappointment-pohlad-says-next-year-will-be-different/

Free agent market (2026–27 class)
23. MLB.com — Ranking the free agents for the 2026-27 offseason (Top 30): https://www.mlb.com/news/ranking-the-free-agents-for-2026-27-offseason
24. Yahoo Sports — Best MLB free agents 2026: Top 16 from Skubal to Arozarena: https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/best-mlb-free-agents-2026-083001562.html
25. CBS Sports — Ranking the top 10 MLB free agents for 2026-27 with landing spots: https://www.cbssports.com/mlb/news/ranking-mlb-free-agency-top-10-2026-27-offseason-landing-spots/
26. MLB Trade Rumors — 2026-27 MLB Free Agent Power Rankings: https://www.mlbtraderumors.com/2026-27-mlb-free-agent-power-rankings
27. Spotrac — Top 10 MLB Free Agents: https://www.spotrac.com/news//*id/3551/top-10-mlb-free-agents*
28. MLB.com — All of the 2026-2027 free agents, position by position: https://www.mlb.com/news/mlb-free-agents-2026-2027
29. The Athletic (paywalled; not directly accessed) — Top 40 MLB free agents with contract predictions. The one use in this brief is Bowden's best-fit teams for Skubal, seen in search excerpts; treat that attribution as secondhand: https://www.nytimes.com/athletic/7711984/2026/10/27/mlb-free-agents-2026-contract-team-predictions/
30. MLB.com — Teruaki Sato to enter MLB posting system: https://www.mlb.com/news/teruaki-sato-mlb-posting-system
31. MLB Trade Rumors — Teruaki Sato player page (posting mechanics and fee schedule): https://www.mlbtraderumors.com/players/teruaki-sato
32. CBS Sports — Teruaki Sato posted: landing spots: https://www.cbssports.com/mlb/news/mlb-free-agency-teruaki-sato-posted-npb-landing-spots/
33. Bolavip — Sato reportedly set for big MLB deal (Bowden 5yr/$180M projection): https://bolavip.com/en/mlb/teruaki-sato-reportedly-set-for-big-mlb-deal-with-ny-yankees-facing-multiple-competitors
33a. Yahoo Sports — Japanese outlet seemingly confirms Seattle's interest in Sato (seven linked teams): https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/japanese-outlet-seemingly-confirms-seattle-150004370.html
33b. ESPN (Kiley McDaniel) — Tarik Skubal's free agency contract, predicted by MLB insiders (27 projections; average 8yr/$355M): https://www.espn.com/mlb/story//id/50071297/mlb-2026-how-tarik-skubal-free-agency-play-predictions-possible-suitors
33c. Sporting News — Tarik Skubal contract projection (9yr/$360M scenario): https://www.sportingnews.com/us/mlb/news/tarik-skubal-contract-projection-dodgers-tigers/13f27a0ca1e75a20f523204c

Trade market
34. Bleacher Report — Ranking the top 25 MLB trade chips for 2026-27: https://bleacherreport.com/articles/25508698-ranking-top-25-mlb-trade-chips-2026-27-offseason
35. Bleacher Report — 6 realistic MLB trades that could happen in 2026-27 (includes the Twins-

Gilbert proposal): https://bleacherreport.com/articles/25505924-6-realistic-mlb-trades-could-happen-2026-27-offseason
36. MLB.com — An early look at 11 intriguing offseason trade candidates: https://www.mlb.com/news/mlb-trade-candidates-for-2026-27-offseason
37. Yahoo Sports — The best MLB trade candidates available before the lockout: https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/best-mlb-trade-candidates-available-120006795.html
38. MLB.com — Breaking down the biggest non-Skubal trade candidates (deadline preview, incl. Joe Ryan fits): https://www.mlb.com/news/potential-mlb-trade-candidates-for-2026
39. CBS Sports — Way-too-early MLB offseason trade candidates: https://www.cbssports.com/mlb/news/way-too-early-mlb-offseason-trade-candidates-2026/
40. Sportskeeda — 10 MLB trade deals that could break the 2026 offseason: https://www.sportskeeda.com/baseball/10-mlb-trade-deals-that-could-break-2026-offseason

Twins farm system
41. MLB.com — Twins Top Prospects (2026 rankings): https://www.mlb.com/twins/prospects/twins
42. MLB.com — Watch these Twins prospects in 2027 after head-turning '26 campaigns: https://www.mlb.com/twins/news/twins-prospects-who-stood-out-in-2026
43. Prospects Live — 2026 Minnesota Twins Top 30 prospects update: https://www.prospectslive.com/2026-minnesota-twins-top-30-prospects-update/
44. Prospects Live — 2027 Dynasty Outlooks: Minnesota Twins: https://www.prospectslive.com/2027-dynasty-outlooks-minnesota-twins/
45. Twins Daily — Updated Twins Daily Top 20 prospects list: https://twinsdaily.com/news-rumors/twins-minor-league/twins-farm-system-updates-breaking-down-the-updated-twins-daily-top-20-prospects-list-r21021/
46. ESPN (Kiley McDaniel) — Updated 2026 top 10 prospect rankings for all 30 teams: https://www.espn.com/mlb/story/_/id/47684227/2026-top-10-prospect-rankings-all-30-mlb-teams-kiley-mcdaniel
47. MLB Pipeline — Twins prospect statistics: https://www.mlb.com/prospects/stats?teamId=142

Extension precedents and trade-return context
48. ESPN — Corbin Carroll, Diamondbacks agree on 8 years, $111M: https://www.espn.com/mlb/story/_/id/35836775/corbin-carroll-diamondbacks-agree-8-years-111m
49. MLB.com — Corbin Carroll signs record extension with D-backs: https://www.mlb.com/news/corbin-carroll-extension-with-d-backs
50. MLB.com — Cubs' 2026 midseason Top 30 prospects update (Wiggins, Kepley context): https://www.mlb.com/cubs/news/cubs-top-30-prospects-2026-midseason-update?t=mlb-pipeline-coverage
51. MLB.com — These players stood out in the Cubs' farm system in '26: https://www.mlb.com/news/cubs-prospects-who-stood-out-in-2026

2026 postseason and AL landscape
52. CBS Sports — 2026 MLB playoff bracket, schedule and scores: https://www.cbssports.com/mlb/news/2026-mlb-playoff-bracket-schedule-scores-results-how-to-watch/
53. Wikipedia — 2026 American League Championship Series: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_American_League_Championship_Series
54. MLB.com — The playoff field is set (2026 bracket and seeds): https://www.mlb.com/news/mlb-playoff-picture-and-bracket-2026
55. ESPN — 2026 MLB playoffs schedule and World Series: https://www.espn.com/mlb/story/*/id/50022544/2026-mlb-playoffs-schedule-how-watch-postseason-world-series-bracket-standings*

56. ESPN (Kiley McDaniel) — Tarik Skubal free agency predictions (source for Skubal's 2026 stats and market): https://www.espn.com/mlb/story//id/50071297/mlb-2026-how-tarik-skubal-free-agency-play-predictions-possible-suitors
57. Yahoo Sports — Mets arrive at $400 million Tarik Skubal decision time: https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/mets-arrive-400-million-tarik-142323262.html